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JOURNEY: ADVOCATES® · LEADER HANDOUT · UNIT 1 · LESSON 4

Logic

BIG IDEA

Scripture treats logic as a vital tool, not a threat: Hebrews calls believers past milk to maturity, Jesus commands loving God with all our mind and models logical argument himself. Students should embrace clear, careful thinking as part of their search for truth, so they can look truth in the face and see Jesus.

Key points from the Leader Video

1. Hebrews 5-6 urges believers to move from spiritual milk to solid food and maturity; Peter and Paul echo the call to renewed, Christ-like minds.
2. Jesus said to worship God with all your heart, soul, mind, and strength, so logic has a clear place in faith.
3. Reductio ad absurdum means drawing an argument to its absurd conclusion, like a dad answering 'all my friends did it' with the jumping-off-a-bridge reply.
4. In Matthew 22 Jesus uses that same logical analysis in his confrontation with the Pharisees.
5. Throughout Acts, in Corinth, Ephesus, Thessalonica, and Athens, Paul constantly reasons from the Scriptures to show who Jesus is.
6. Some arguments against Christianity sound good, so discuss them honestly, gauging what your students are ready to handle before diving in.

SCRIPTURE IN THE VIDEO

Matthew 22

FOR YOU

Before club: think it through yourself.

1. Should faith make sense? What parts of faith seem confusing until you think them through?
2. What about your faith does not make sense to you, and what would it take to work through it?
3. How do you already use logic in your relationships to figure out what is true?
4. What is an argument against Christianity that sounds good, and does it hold up logically?

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WEEK 4 · LEADER VIDEO

The full transcript

The talk from this week's Leader Video, lightly edited for reading. Times point back to that moment in the video.

Why talk about logic

0:05 Now you might be asking, why in the world are we talking about logic? Certainly it makes sense to talk about faith. Certainly it makes sense to talk about truth. But why would we take an entire week out, in a Bible study, to talk about something so strange as logic? Well, I think it starts with what the writer of Hebrews says in the last part of chapter 5 and the early part of chapter 6.

0:31 Anyone who lives on milk, still an infant, is not acquainted with the teaching about righteousness, but solid food is for the mature, who by constant use have trained themselves to distinguish good from evil. Therefore, let us leave the elementary teachings about Christ and go on to maturity. Peter says much the same thing about leaving the idea of spiritual milk and moving on to maturity. Paul says, be transformed in the renewing of your minds, and put off the old self and put on the new self, imitate God, have a mind like Christ.

1:09 And even Jesus said we need to worship God with all of our heart, with all of our soul, with all of our mind, and with all of our strength. It's clear throughout Scripture that logic has a place, and that it is a tool that shouldn't be considered a threat. In fact, it's an incredibly useful tool. After all, Jesus said it — and in fact, you'll find in the Bible study this week that Jesus even demonstrated it.

Reduce to absurdity

1:40 We'll see a couple of strange things throughout the study, and one of those things is this weird term you see in Latin, called reductio ad absurdum. I'll say that again: reductio ad absurdum. Essentially, it's just a fancy Latin word that means reduce to absurdity. It's that simple — and even that seems kind of confusing. So let me give you an example that should help you explain this kind of strange concept to your students.

2:13 When I was a kid, every so often I would skip school, and this one time in particular my dad caught me. So naturally he asked me, why did you skip school? I had this genius idea, this genius logic that I had come up with, and I told him, well, all my friends were doing it, so that's why I did it. That makes sense. That made perfect sense in my head, and I kind of stood there waiting for him to make a response. He didn't take very long before he said, well, if all of your friends jumped off a bridge, would you too?

2:48 Essentially, what my dad was doing, whether he realized it or not, was taking my argument and drawing it out to its natural conclusion, which is absurd. And that's essentially what reductio ad absurdum is telling us. And when we see Matthew 22, that's Jesus engaging in the same sort of logical analysis in his confrontation with the Pharisees. So instead of fearing logic, our goal is to

get students to embrace logic, and actually to get them to understand that logic is a vital tool in the search for truth.

Logic in the search for truth

3:25 Remember what we're doing here throughout this process — we talked about this when we talked about truth: students are looking for what is true. We want students, at the end of this process, to be able to look truth squarely in the face and actually see Jesus. So logic is going to help them get to that point. In their intro experience, we want them first to actually see that in their relationships. Students are using logic in their relationships to search for truth in those relationships, and we want them to do the same thing with Jesus.

Paul reasoned from Scripture

3:58 So take Paul, for example. If you look through Acts — whether Paul's in Corinth, whether he's in Ephesus, whether Paul's in Thessalonica or in Athens — what you see is that Paul is constantly using logic. He's reasoning from the Scriptures, helping them understand who Jesus is, what he's all about, and what salvation means. Essentially, Paul uses logic through and through in almost every single one of his arguments as he's traveling on his missionary journeys. So the idea is that we want to invite students into a space where they can be curious, where they can not only ask the questions but logically think through these things and add an intellectual piece to their faith.

Small group time

4:43 As you dive into small group, you're going to ask what looks like a really simple question: should faith make sense? That's kind of tricky, right? There's a little bit going on here that we need to address, because there's so much about Jesus that does not seem to make sense. There's so much about our faith that doesn't seem to make sense sometimes. But as we think through it, as we use logic, as we actually engage intellectually with our faith, there's a lot we can figure out, and God has given us the tools to do so.

5:13 And really, this is much of the Pharisees' problem. This is what we see from question one and from their motivation to get after Jesus. They just didn't really get it. But I want to take a second and really touch on question three, because it deals with potential arguments against Christianity and whether or not those arguments make sense.

5:36 Be careful here, but answer these honestly — talk about these honestly — because there are some arguments out there that sound pretty good, that seem to make some sense. But that doesn't mean they're logical, and it doesn't make them right. It just makes them additional arguments. Even so, a lot of them are worth talking about. Just make sure you gauge your students and know where they're at. If you don't think your students can handle it, that may be a question you want to sidestep for just a minute and then come back to when you think they're ready.

Sending students out

6:05 So as students depart for this week, leave them with this question: what about your faith doesn't make sense to you? And challenge them with what it's going to take to spur them on to a mature faith. Because remember, Jesus calls us all to clear and careful thinking — the same kind of thinking that Jesus demonstrated.